

Principia Humana: An investigation of modern human life H1

Suffering is perhaps the most phenomenologically under-explored space of the modern human life. The suffering behind closed doors, financial stress, judicial injustice, societal issues, undiagnosed health issues, proposterous medical bills, unsolved crimes.

All of this is absolutely suffocating. I understand... this is most likely where people turn to Hedonism as an anesthetic to the debilitating confrontation; the engine of life we are part of, is imperfect and festering with issues, and nobody can single-handedly solve.

Yet, within this clockwork, there are methods of response, and in some cases; very few modes which justify the conditions of present-day life and make it necessary for human growth and well-being, and as consequence; one of the fundamental sources of meaning acting as a shield against the imperfect structures of life; rather than an agent of sedation. (...this however, may be too philosophically dense for this study.)

Of these belief systems, I base a developing idea on "ethics + problem solving" as the baseline; not a dogma. (...this is separate, however...)

Abstract

H2

The study begins with a breakthrough problem... "Why is modern life so disproportionately distributed? Why do some people suffer so criminally behind closed doors, whilst we undoubtedly possess the necessary infrastructure to feed and clothe everyone?"

Naturally, this discussion seeps across the Cynical, Nihilistic, Existential territories; so I attempt to center on Hedonism as a calibration for these ideas; in a more productive lens, using Hedonic principles (pain and pleasure) as fundamental, indisputable elements of phenomenological reality, and more importantly; How we may respond, properly, as people, to this complex social arachnoweb (a model i'm describing for complex phenomenological issues);

Where nobody appears to possess a plan, or model of social restructuring... while those are more sociopolitical ideas, the purpose of this study is to productively investigate how a single person should conduct oneself in today's world.

Given the heart of series, we explore Hedonism; the belief that the greatest and most correct pursuit of human life, should be that of maximizing pleasure, and minimizing pain.

I present 6 arguments on the catastrophic insufficiency and effects of Social Hedonism, and additionally; a story of Hedonism, and why this discussion is more significant to be had today, than it was at it's historical conception in ancient Greece. The positive applications of concepts of Hedonism (generally shallow lifestyle, but some ideas are useful if integrated.)

A proposed explanation of today's conditions

H2

We may not realize it, but much of the unjust conditions of modern day human life, is by the afterimage of a net of once, sane philosophies and schools of thought. Mostly born out of Greece and other civilizations, eventually pathologized into a careless lifestyle. We explore how this perpetuates the very suffering Hedonism attempts to minimize, and how we may properly respond instead.

Central Arguments

H2

1. Perpetuation: Hedonism perpetuates suffering, not merely by productive inaction (which is a default consequence of not acting diligently, in general), but by feeding the imbalance of the world and starving resources by those who need it. (This is the most catastrophic, undeniable effect of Socio-Hedonism.), These effects become observable as injustices in the world we live in, feeding cynicism, nihilism and other forms of destructive philosophy-driven lifestyles. Despite possessing unimaginably powerful models and technology; primitive issues such as starvation and judicial inequality (amongst other socioeconomic issues.) persist today. These issues are largely unnoticed by the wealthy; and largely, they are indirectly, yet hierarchically responsible for the suffering of millions of people and forms of life; by Hedonic, self-serving behavior. Again, this is the most catastrophic point of Hedonism. It does not imply Hedonism is the only source of cruelty and injustice (pathology and psychopathy included...), but it does keep the study centered on observable slices of the whole; so that we may formulate a cohesive response, for everyday human life.
2. Localized: Entirely dependent on local sense of pleasure. This is a finite, exhaustive, sensitive resource, and biologically; pathways shared with pain itself. It is ironic, to say the least.
3. Insufficient and Incomplete: Does not present a full or accurate model of the world and of human life; failing to integrate both; the tragic conditions of suffering, and the human moral responsibility to confront it willingly.
4. Incongruence; Meaning is not the same as pleasure; even if those inter-sections often reveal in positive emotion towards goals (we may study this separately.) Viktor Frankl's life is evident of this, through the most tragic of lenses. By this same vein of inquiry, Hedonism is not a designer alternative to meaning; the only force that justifies the conditions of life, and sustains the finite human being against the non-finite, is the voluntary, unconditional participation of life. (...This is a paraphrasing of Frankl's life's work.)

5. Fragile. Hedonism does not prepare oneself for tragedy, nor does it strengthen the structure of local community to withstand the conditions of life. (...this is a deep section, we should emphasize eventually...) The human being is both; biologically fragile yet willfully resilient. Hedonism isolates our fragility and maximizes our helplessness; yet society did not develop that way.
6. Cybernetically incomplete. From the previous point, Hedonism only exists in part of developed society. Hunter gatherers actually did exhibit hedonic lifestyles; but nowhere near the distribution of today's wealth. Hedonism is Cybernetically incomplete when analyzed from the moral domain; it does not contain sufficient resources for the exchange of values or service outside the localized, isolated cluster of pleasure-seeking agents. In other words; Hedonism is synonymous with free-radicals; self-serving to their own code, regardless of the larger structure of being. Which is obviously dangerous. Especially at social scale.

Summary: drawing a normal from these arguments; Hedonism fails precisely at the boundary where philosophies and lifestyles confront the very nature of life and reality itself; no (sophisticated) system can persist as a consequence of single-channel optimization. Even at the biological, mechanical, cyber levels of analysis; isolated optimization dies against the multi-factorial environment. That's a brutal blow to the idea that "we can just be happy, and the pain will go away."

Architecture of philosophy

H2

Hedonism, due to its comically shallow depth, reveals how little it takes for a person to adopt an entire mode of living; Architecture of philosophy, as well as goal-seeking, models of belief and value systems.

This also presents a deeply interesting idea for a separate conversation (if Hedonism is a lifestyle and philosophy, and it reveals the essential components for behavioral change; it becomes implicit and habitual in one's approach to life... eventually integrating itself into one's character... a mode of being is indistinguishable from a personality... perhaps this shapes our very perception itself; since perception is closely linked to goal-seeking... and as such... perhaps this is where phenomenology becomes Scientific! ... for a different conversation.)

Hedonism expresses minimal architecture;

- Fundamental Belief, values, ideas
- Conditions: such as the undeniable unchangeable nature of pain
- Process: the belief becomes implicit and habitual; integrating into oneself.
- Action: the belief carries a will of its own, influencing and in some cases, causing action.
(this deserves investigation however.)

Foundation

H3

However, Hedonism makes it's foundational beliefs another implicit structure; where do beliefs come from? This is the foundation we lay our assumptions, ideas and beliefs on. The key idea here is "foundation." This presents an axiom: "On what foundation is the structure of human life founded on?" Jordan B. Peterson investigates this through the Scientific, Mythic and Moral. Those are perhaps the three most important domains to human life; they model a structure closer to the foundation of reality, than any single given philosophy. (...we can develop this too...)

Structural analysis of Hedonism

H3

If Hedonism is rooted on the sands of bodily sensation, as it's base foundation, then perhaps it reveals a significant component of philosophy; the foundation we lay our assumptions (axioms or ideas, established or accepted truths, faith, beliefs, etc.), is the sustenance that stands the test when the environmental pressures (in modern human life, the environmental pressures are the very conditions we face, no longer territorial; but phenomenological.) collapse the very structures we build. This is where people either crash into Depression, Nihilism, Cynicism and other pathologies, or they remain at bedrock.

Component of the sustainable belief system

H2

In this sense, a sustainable philosophy or belief system, is not a model; but the very foundation it is built upon. The foundation, according to my ongoing research, appears to be a voluntary confrontation with the conditions of life; and a moral responsibility to act diligently everyday.

This elevates Christianity, Islam, Buddhism and the various life's work of people like Viktor Frankl. They do not begin with "this is how we respond" they begin with humility "this is how life works" only later is the foundation built upon... "this is how we may respond properly."

Naivety

H2

Hedonism may be either; a result of naivety, or a purposeful seclusion of the conditions of life; an integrated model of life.

A child who wants to be happy is an ethical duty for a parent; however, such child must also prepare for confrontation with the inevitable non-happiness of life; challenge, duty, betrayal, pain, suffering, rejoice, growth, expectation, improvement... there are countless dimensions of human life; none can be isolated. Meaning emerges as a network, Hedonism isolates the most immediately gratifying cluster of that network. It's effects are devastating at social scale.

Incomplete models are less dangerous than Insufficient models. H2

Arguably, we do not possess a full model of reality; nor would such a model be useful, relevant, understandable or applicable to human life. However, we are measuring usefulness and ethics; not native resolution. Some models are more sustainable than others, and some models are

catastrophically incomplete. The model which lasts the longest, may perhaps be the model which continuously adapts and updates based on what is real; and what is responsible; and what is actionable; and what is sustainable... (...still working on this part...)

The full nature of human life, the conditions that beset all living things, and the nature of reality; are all fundamentally unknown. However, we may eventually accept; pain and pleasure are undeniably, phenomenologically real.

This is the beginning of human belief systems; when we agree "this is real." Because without a basis on fundamental reality, we have no foundations to lay upon, and thus, no supporting structure, and thus, no life.

Life begins with structure, (atleast as useful as it is for us to understand). It unravels into complexity and sophistication, and the eternal conflict between chaos and order, emerges...

Hedonism is not entirely incorrect

H2

This is where I acknowledge one idea: human life cannot be defined by suffering; because this is making the same, grave mistake as Hedonism; assuming a single-dimensional model.

How we may live, in response to the conditions of life. Hedonism actually originated as a school of balance; it only later became stripped of its grounded equilibrium and pathologized into the disproportionately wealthy society we see today.

Hedonism is unsustainable and insufficient; life is too complex and disproportionately distributed. It perpetuates this distribution (often pareto-based distributions, or bell curves, as seen in politics and socio-economics.) and undoubtedly feeds the fire of Cynicism; the belief that most people only care about themselves, Apathy; general carelessness (extremely dangerous), Nihilism: the belief nothing matters because life is painful,

Hedonism is the embodiment of living in the clouds, it is an admirable attempt at confronting the nature of life; but ultimately self-destructive and mutually corrosive.

Elusiveness

H2

Hedonic life-styles present a designer lifestyle. This is the modern redux of the fairy-tale, as applied to modern, wealthy, access.

The problem with this is stated in the first argument; it consequently perpetuates Cynicism because the disproportionate distribution of resources

The price of the Hedonist

H2

There is a price to be paid for prioritizing self gratifying behavior.

Hedonism would make sense in an isolated community, where the avoidance of pain would naturally leave room for pleasure. That makes sense from a logical, biological (notice the "logic" root words in these terms.) lens of analysis; however, the human being is neither; an entirely logical creature, nor a purely instinctual creature.

When we mis-use our remarkable human-defining abilities (intelligence, problem solving, reasoning, abstraction, personality, etc.) not only does the larger scale society pay a price for this perpetual indulgence; but one's conscience will undoubtedly either crash or become tormented.

Philosophy and Lifestyle as models

H2

Philosophy and Lifestyles are not merely "modes" of style, they are models of living. They prepare and shape us for the undeniable unknown events taking place in the future.

The human being belong to "being" itself; becoming. In later sections I express how Hedonism itself only exists because of the collective effort of organized society; which is a distributed responsibility. Each member is a node on a network, with a significant effect. (...butterfly effect may be useful to express this section.)

Coda

H2

What may we apply from the ideas discussed in this study? If anything, I present the "yin yang" symbol of dualism, as a foundational baseline for proper human life, and mechanical systems. Neither pure optimization nor naive operation; in essence, that is the art of engineering. One of the foundational reasons society even developed at all; and why Hedonism

Yet, I also acknowledge; Hedonism presents a source of meaning that is not essential from suffering; often in life, a moment does not require explanation in order to be meaningful. This however, must not be applied as a coherent lifestyle; human life cannot be defined merely by how we think, or how we live; but how we act and respond. (...still working on this part...)

A concluding idea is something i'm developing... "Regardless of our incomplete models, the unjust imperfect conditions of life and systems in general, Everything must be measured in balance, relative to and according to the highest good we know of." ...still working on that thesis... not as a closing final knot, but a melody of contribution to the collective symphony, which unravels and reveals the orders of life, the more we understand how to hear it. (...that's also a separate discussion!

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